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The Gendered Division of Housework and Couples' Sexual Relationships: A Reexamination

Although contemporary couples increasingly express preferences for egalitarian unions, previous research has suggested that sexual intimacy decreases when routine housework is shared. Yet this research was conducted on data that are decades old. To update this work, the authors compared data from the 2006 Marital and Relationship Survey (MARS) and Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households (NSFH2), collected in 1992–1994. The results indicated change in the association between housework arrangements and sexual intimacy across surveys. Although egalitarian arrangements were associated with lower sexual frequency compared to conventional arrangements in the NSFH2, no such difference was found in the MARS. In fact, reported sexual frequency increased across surveys among egalitarian couples only. In addition, how housework was arranged mattered more for sexual satisfaction among MARS couples than NSFH2 couples. These changes appear to result from the increasing role of perceived equity as a mechanism linking the division of housework to sex.

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Today's adults, especially those born after 1960, came of age during a period of great upheaval in expected family and work roles for men and women. They are the "children of the gender revolution" (Gerson, 2010). As adults, many seek to build families based on egalitarian roles, including an equitable sharing of domestic and financial burdens (Gerson, 2010; Pedulla & Thébaud, 2015). They also desire high levels of intimacy within their partnerships (Cherlin, 2004; Gerson, 2010). Indeed, these cohorts expect the "total package": someone who will be helpmate, best friend, and lover. Transforming conventional gender roles can, however, be challenging. There may be consequences for seeking to overturn normative gender scripts. Egalitarian unions can be difficult to maintain (e.g., Miller & Sassler, 2010; Risman, 1998; P. Schwartz, 1995), especially when there are few established models for couples to follow. Sharing domestic

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burdens may also lead to less intimacy between partners (Kornrich, Brines, & Leupp, 2013; P. Schwartz, 1995). In a recent article published in *The American Sociological Review,* Kornrich and colleagues (Kornrich, Brines, & Leupp, 2013) found that sexual frequency was highest in married households with conventionally gendered divisions of labor and declined as men and women increased their shares of nontraditional housework tasks.

Much of what we know about gender, household tasks, and intimate relationships—including the article by Kornrich and colleagues (2013)—is based on analyses of data from the second wave of the National Survey of Families and Households (NSFH2; see http://www.ssc.wisc.edu/nsfh/). The first wave of data for the NSFH was gathered in 1987–1988, and the same respondents were followed up in 1992–1994 (Sweet & Bumpass, 1996). Although the revolution in men's and women's roles has changed only a little since the 1990s (e.g., today's women do slightly more paid work and men slightly more housework compared to 20 years ago), men's and women's attitudes about the gendered division of labor have become increasingly egalitarian (Gerson, 2010; Sayer, 2010).

Given shifts in the family behaviors of contemporary couples and adults' aspirations for egalitarian family lives, we might expect changes in the association between the division of domestic labor and couples' sexual relationships. Feelings of fairness and satisfaction with the division of housework are central to couples' relationship satisfaction (Amato, Johnson, Booth, & Rogers, 2003; Frisco & Williams, 2003; Wilkie, Ferree, & Ratcliff, 1998), which is strongly related to sexual intimacy (Call, Sprecher, & Schwartz, 1995; P. Schwartz, 2007; Sprecher & Cate, 2004). In this study we explored how the division of household labor is associated with couples' sexual frequency and satisfaction in the early years of the 21st century compared to couples initially surveyed 20 years earlier. Data are from the second wave of the NSFH and the Marital and Relationship Survey (MARS), a 2006 survey that collected data from a sample of low- to moderate-income couples with a minor child living in the home (Lichter & Carmalt, 2009; Sassler, Addo, & Lichter, 2012). We limited the NSFH2 sample to be comparable with the MARS sample and constructed measures that both replicate those of prior studies and diverge in important ways that we suggest better reflect behavioral outcomes. Our findings provide further evidence that the gender revolution has reshaped important aspects of family life (Cotter, Hermsen, & Vanneman, 2011; C. R. Schwartz & Han, 2014).

Background

The Performance of Gender in Intimate Unions

An extensive body of research has examined how gender is reinforced through interactions with others (Potuchek, 1997; Risman, 2004; West & Zimmerman, 1987). Researchers have examined how couples do gender through union progression, expressions of sexuality and sexual pleasure, and decision making (cf. Blumberg & Coleman, 1989; Miller & Sassler, 2012; Sassler & Miller, 2011). Perhaps no area has been examined quite so much as the division of household chores (for reviews of the literature, see Coltrane, 2000, and Sayer, 2010).

Men have increased their shares of routine housework over time, and women have reduced theirs, thereby narrowing the gender gap in household labor (Bianchi, Sayer, Milkie, & Robinson, 2012). Women's greater responsibilities within the home historically were linked to their lower earnings, fewer hours worked, or inferior educational attainment (cf. Carlson & Lynch, 2013; Coltrane, 2000). But as women increasingly entered the paid labor force, attitudes toward domestic labor shifted (Thornton & Young-DeMarco, 2001). Both men and women now report in attitudinal surveys that men should participate in domestic labor; the vast majority of both sexes reject the notion of separate spheres. Although women persistently express stronger adherence to egalitarian beliefs, men do not lag that far behind (http://ropercenter.cornell.edu/ipoll-database/).

Nevertheless, women continue to perform disproportionate shares of domestic labor (Bianchi et al., 2012). Even in households where the female partner earns more than the male, is more educated, or works more hours per week, men do less routine housework than their partners (e.g., Brines, 1994; Greenstein, 1996; Tichenor, 1999). It is clear that something about the expected roles of men and women, and not just the relative resources of each partner, contributes to the ways couples organized their household labor.

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There is some evidence, however, that previous associations between women's advantages and union outcomes have shifted. Men's participation within the family has changed over the past few decades. They have increased their involvement in child care, especially when their wives are employed (Raley, Bianchi, & Wang, 2012; Sayer, Bianchi, & Robinson, 2004). Studies have also documented a sizable increase over the final three decades of the 20th century in the time men spend on core housework activities such as cooking and cleaning (Sayer, 2005). There is also evidence that other manifestations of gender equality, such as women's growing bargaining power within intimate unions, are no longer associated with an elevated likelihood of union dissolution (C. R. Schwartz & Han, 2014). These results suggest that egalitarianism within couples has become the cultural ideal. We might therefore expect the association between egalitarian divisions of household labor and sexual frequency to have shifted from those reported in the decades immediately following the gender revolution (Bianchi et al., 2012).

Housework and Sex in Intimate Unions

The division of household labor and sexual intimacy are closely intertwined, given that they involve the enactment of gender norms, desire, and power (Blumberg & Coleman, 1989; Elliott & Umberson, 2008). Past theories derived from the new home economics posited that role complementarity strengthens marriages, and the performance of conventional roles increases relationship satisfaction and, ostensibly, sexual frequency (Becker, 1981). This theoretical premise undergirds a recent study that suggested that complementarity served as an integral trigger for sexual scripts. Using data collected over two decades ago, Kornrich and colleagues (2013) argued that expressions of gender difference in the performance of household labor create sexual desire. In their words, "traditionally masculine and feminine behaviors consciously or unconsciously serve as turn-ons for individuals" (p. 31) by enacting the sexual scripts necessary to produce arousal (Simon & Gagnon, 1986). They found that sexual frequency was highest in NSFH2 couples with traditionally gendered divisions of household labor. In households where men did a greater proportion of female-typed routine tasks, reports of sexual frequency were significantly lower, as was wives' sexual satisfaction. Their results are consistent with those of P. Schwartz's (1995) qualitative study, which found that peer marriages often posed problems for sexual intimacy, in part because such relationships were nonnormative.

Today, role complementarity is not the only, or even the most desirable, model for intimate relationships. Gerson (2010) found that today's young adults prefer a partner who is their equal both at work and at home, and Pedulla and Thébaud's (2015) experimental design revealed that even when respondents stated a preference for traditional arrangements, this was often attributable to workplace constraints and unsupportive workplace policies. These changing desires to share household tasks suggest that egalitarianism will be positively related to sexual frequency and satisfaction, as contemporary couples view conventional and egalitarian housework arrangements from a very different lens than 20 years ago. This matters, because satisfaction with and perceptions of the fairness of housework performed are central to couples' sexual intimacy. Sex has value not only as a gender performance but also as a means of demonstrating love and affection. As such, couples have more and higher quality sex when they are satisfied with their relationships (Call et al., 1995; P. Schwartz, 2007; Sprecher & Cate, 2004). Relationship quality and stability are generally highest when couples are happy with their divisions of labor and find them equitable and fair (Amato et al., 2003; Frisco & Williams, 2003; Wilkie et al., 1998). The evidence shows that when men do a greater share of housework, wives' perceptions of relationship fairness and marital satisfaction are greater (Amato et al., 2003). Moreover, even several decades ago couples in egalitarian unions reported high levels of emotional closeness (P. Schwartz, 1995) and communication (Risman, 1998). Taken as a whole, these results suggest that several decades after the gender revolution, greater sharing of domestic labor may result in different associations with relationship satisfaction, sexual satisfaction, and physical intimacy than were observed in the immediate aftermath of the gender revolution.

Because men and women often disagree on what constitutes a fair or satisfying division of labor (Dillaway & Broman, 2001; Frisco & Williams, 2003; Sanchez & Kane, 1996), there may be gender differences in the association of the division of housework with sexual intimacy

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among partners, especially regarding feelings of sexual satisfaction. Men and women often perceive their divisions of labor very differently; indeed, they frequently disagree about how much labor each partner performs. Men are more likely than their female partners to report that the couple's division of labor is equal, whereas women are more likely to state they do the majority of housework (e.g., Lee & Waite, 2005; Parker & Wang, 2013). This divergence can be attributed, in part, to women inflating the time they spend on housework substantially more than they overstate their husbands' housework contributions; husbands, in contrast, tend to overstate both their own time and their wives' time more consistently (Lee & Waite, 2005).

Not only do partners often disagree about how much each contributes, but men and women also feel differently about their arrangements. Consistent with Jessie Bernard's (1972) notion of "his" and "her" marriages, women have stronger beliefs than do men that housework should be shared (Hohmann-Marriott, 2006; John, Shelton, & Luschen, 1995) and are therefore more likely than men to see gender-conventional arrangements as unfair and feel less satisfied with such relationships (Greenstein, 1996). Perceptions of fairness (equity), however, appear more important than actual contributions (equality; Gager, 1998; John et al., 1995), and other research has found that the effect of perceived equity on marital happiness is gender invariant (Frisco & Williams, 2003). Whether the association between the division of housework and sexual intimacy differs by gender or if this association has changed over time remain open questions.

Rather than stemming only from an eroticism of difference through a conventional division of labor (P. Schwartz, 1995), a satisfying sex life might also be related to an eroticism of fairness. Indeed, if couples (or one partner alone) view traditional arrangements as less fair or satisfying today than in the past or view egalitarian arrangements more positively, this will have significant consequences for the relationship between the division of household labor and couples' sexual intimacy. Several qualitative studies have provided hints that the tide might be shifting for couples in more egalitarian arrangements, in favor of more frequent sexual encounters. These studies reported that women encourage egalitarian arrangements by rewarding partners sexually for their housework performance or punishing them for deficient domestic contributions (Elliott & Umberson, 2008; Hochschild, 1989). Elliott and Umberson (2008) also found that some husbands intentionally increased the amount of housework they did in order to encourage their wives to have sex more often.

Despite abundant evidence that men's and women's roles are converging there is little indication that either men or women are embracing a script in which men are the primary homemakers—an arrangement we label *counter-conventional*. Rarely do men take on the majority of the housework, but when they do, performing the lion's share of household labor is generally not viewed as "making up for" their lesser financial contributions (Hochschild, 1989; Miller & Sassler, 2012). Indeed, such arrangements are often problematized by couples, viewed as the result of constraints rather than choice (Damaske, 2011; Tichenor, 2005). In their famous theoretical essay on the balance of power within the family, Blumburg and Coleman (1989) argued that couples whose economic roles were in transition would experience more power struggles, which would negatively affect their sex lives. They hypothesized that as men became more economically dependent on their wives they would "adopt the dependent wife's traditional leverage of rationing sex or making excuses [to avoid it]" (p. 242). If this also applies to transitions in domestic roles, counter-conventional couples may have sex less frequently, because women have less frequent and intense sexual desire than men (Baumeister, Catanese, & Vohs, 2001; Elliott & Umberson, 2008), and providing or withholding sex by men will be of lower bargaining power. Some research has also suggested that a reversal of conventional gender roles may reduce sexual frequency and satisfaction because it can lead to erectile dysfunction and difficulty for men in obtaining an orgasm (Cornwell & Laumann, 2011).

On the basis of our theoretical framework, we formulated the following hypotheses:

> *Hypothesis 1:* We expected that the associations of the division of household labor with sexual frequency and satisfaction will change across cohorts. Studies based on the NSFH2 cohort have found the highest levels of sexual frequency among couples who adhered to conventional divisions of housework (where the woman does the majority of housework). Among the 2006 MARS sample,

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we expected lower levels of sexual frequency and sexual satisfaction among couples who reported conventional arrangements when compared to couples with more egalitarian divisions of household labor. We also expect counter-conventional couples to report lower levels of sexual frequency and sexual satisfaction relative to their egalitarian counterparts.

Hypothesis 2: We expected that the relationship between the division of routine housework and sexual frequency and satisfaction will be mediated by reports of satisfaction with the division of housework, feelings of fairness about the division of housework, and overall relationship satisfaction.

Other Factors Influencing Sexual Frequency and Satisfaction

Of course, many factors are associated with couples' sexual relationships. Key among these are the presence and age of children (Call et al., 1995), religious affiliation and attendance (Call et al., 1995), the total number of hours couples spend doing housework (Gager & Yabiku, 2010), and educational attainment (Kornrich et al., 2013). More recently, scholars have begun paying attention to the relationship between sexual frequency and health as well (Call et al., 1995; Gager & Yabiku, 2010; Kornrich et al., 2013).

Union status is also an important factor but one that has received little attention in examinations of how housework arrangements are associated with sexual intimacy. Contemporary union patterns also differ in important ways from the processes enacted 25 years ago. Marriage is an increasingly selective institution, which may help tilt the balance toward greater rewards for more equally shared housework and away from conventional exchanges. Cohabitation is also more prevalent in the early years of the 21st century than it was in the closing decades of the 20th (Manning, 2013). Prior research has found that cohabitors often prefer more egalitarian arrangements than do married couples, although, in those studies, cohabiting women still did more hours of paid labor than did cohabiting men (Clarkberg, Stolzenberg, & Waite, 1995; Shelton & John, 1993). But cohabiting couples from the 1980s who practiced conventional divisions of labor were more likely to marry than their more egalitarian counterparts (Sanchez, Manning, & Smock, 1998). At the same time, individuals who cohabited prior to marriage report lower relationship quality (Sassler et al., 2012; Stanley, Rhoades, & Markman, 2006). The experience of premarital cohabitation, which has become normative among couples married over the past few decades (Manning, 2013), may therefore change how couples negotiate the division of domestic work (Miller & Sassler, 2010).

The Current Study

In this study we examined whether the association between egalitarian divisions of domestic work and lower levels of sexual frequency and reduced sexual satisfaction have weakened over time. We used data gathered midway through the first decade of the 21st century, which was drawn from a sample of low- to moderate-income married and cohabiting couples with minor children, and compared them to a similarly constructed subsample from the NSFH2. Although data limitations constrained our focus to a segment of American society often designated as working to lower middle class, we argue that this provides a more conservative test of the extent to which gender roles have changed. The working class, in particular working-class men, have traditionally expressed more gender-traditional attitudes and behaviors than professionals regarding the division of paid and domestic labor (Blair-Loy, 2003; Rubin, 1994). Social class differences in the division of domestic labor have narrowed, however, and more equal sharing is now more evident among working-class as well as middle-class households (Damaske, 2011; Shows & Gerstel, 2009).

In addition, our analysis moved beyond purely linear measurements of men's and women's domestic labor contributions. We divided our couples into three types: (a) conventional couples, in which the woman did the majority (65% or more) of the housework; (b) egalitarian couples, in which the male partner performed between 35% and 65% of the domestic labor; and (c) counter-conventional households, in which men performed the majority (65% or more) of the housework. Previous research has found these typologies to be more salient among contemporary couples and to best demarcate different ways in which couples "do gender" or transform it (Miller & Carlson, 2015; Miller & Sassler, 2012).

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Method

Data

For this study we used data from the MARS and the NSFH2. The MARS is an Internet-based survey conducted in March and April of 2006 by Knowledge Networks using probability sampling. Knowledge Networks provides ongoing household panelists with an Internet appliance, Internet access, Web TV, and a cash payment for completing surveys to reduce the exclusion of members of disadvantaged backgrounds. The response rate was 80.3% (Lichter & Carmalt, 2009). The MARS sample was restricted to couples with coresident minor children and female partners under age 45. The MARS also oversampled low- to moderate-income couples. Both married and cohabiting respondents were sampled, and information was collected independently from both partners. A total of 1,095 individuals in 605 couples were interviewed. Because we were interested in controlling for several couple-level variables, such as the female partners' share of income, partner's work hours, and couples' total incomes and total hours of housework per week, we limited our sample to those 487 couples in which both partners completed the survey.

Data also came from Wave 2 (1992–1994) of the NSFH. Of the 13,017 households interviewed in the first wave, 10,005 were reinterviewed in 1992–1994. We used a subsample of the NSFH2 whose demographic characteristics were comparable to those of the MARS respondents. We restricted our analysis to both married and cohabiting couples with coresident minor children and a female partner under age 45. We also restricted the sample, as did Kornrich and colleagues (2013), to couples who provided at least eight (out of 18) valid responses to the nine housework item questions asked of both partners, yielding 52.5% ($n = 5{,}249$) of the 10,005 Wave 2 households; of this group, 62.9% ($n = 3{,}303$) had a minor child living in the household. Of these couples, 80.7% ($n = 2{,}664$) had a female partner less than age 45.

Because of oversampling of low-income couples in the MARS and in order to construct comparable samples, we restricted the MARS and NSFH2 in the following manner to produce similar income distributions. Income in the MARS was truncated at the 95th percentile ($90,000), and the NSFH2 was truncated at $44,500 ($63,635 in 2006 dollars). Restricting the samples this way resulted in nearly identical income distributions. The mean income for both samples was approximately $38,300 (in 2006 dollars), with interquartile ranges of approximately $26,000 to $50,000 (in 2006 dollars). These restrictions result in a final sample size of 932 for the MARS and 2,628 for the NSFH2.

Measures

Dependent variables. For the sake of comparability, the measures used in this study mirrored as closely as possible those from Kornrich et al.'s (2013) analysis of the NSFH2. *Sexual frequency per month* was based on each respondent's answer to the question, "About how many times did you and your [spouse/partner] have sex last month?" We truncated reports of sexual frequency at the 95th percentile in both data sets to account for extreme outliers in the data.

In addition to sexual frequency, we included a measure of respondents' satisfaction with the couple's sexual relationship. Although sexual satisfaction is associated with sexual frequency (Brody & Costa, 2009), we investigated both because they tap different aspects of sexual intimacy. Indeed, individuals' definitions of sexual satisfaction include both personal sexual well-being (positive individual sexual experiences, including pleasure, arousal, and orgasm) as well as dyadic processes, such as mutuality, romance, and frequency of sexual activity (Fincham, 2006; Pascoal, Ide, & Pereira, 2014). In the MARS we assessed *sexual satisfaction* as respondents' level of agreement with the statement "I am satisfied with our sexual relationship." Possible responses to this item included 0 = "strongly disagree," 1 = "disagree," 2 = "agree," and 3 = "strongly agree." In the NSFH2, respondents' satisfaction with their sexual relationships was assessed with the question, "How happy are you with your sexual relationship?" Responses ranged from 0 = *very unhappy* to 7 = *very happy*. To adjust the differential scaling of these variables, we mean-centered each measure and represented it in terms of standard deviations.

Independent variables. Our primary independent variable was the division of routine housework. We limited our analysis to routine housework, as questions regarding nonroutine housework were nonexhaustive and limited to home repairs and bill paying in the MARS. Respondents in the MARS reported their divisions on the following

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routine items: preparing and cooking meals, washing dishes, cleaning around the house, shopping for groceries, and doing laundry. These items are universally considered core or routine housework tasks that are traditionally the responsibility of women (Coltrane, 2000). Responses to these questions ranged from 0 ("I do it all") through 2 ("We share it equally") to 4 ("My partner does it all"). We recoded each measure into 0 (She does it all), 2 (We share it equally), and 4 (He does it all). We then summed these five items and averaged the total to create a summary measure, ranging from 0 to 4, indicating the respondent's report of *male partners' share of routine housework*. Higher scores on this measure indicate a less conventional arrangement, whereby the male partner does greater amounts of routine housework.

To assess differences between conventional (female partner is responsible for the majority of routine housework), egalitarian (couple shares the routine housework relatively equally), and counter-conventional (male partner is responsible for the majority of routine housework) couples we created three dummy variables. Each dummy stands for approximately one third of the distribution of housework shares. Individuals were a given a value of 1 on *she does majority of the routine housework* if the score on the division of routine housework measure was less than 1.4—the equivalent of the male partner doing 35% or less of the housework. Respondents were coded as 1 on *routine housework shared equally* if the score on the division of routine housework was between 1.4 and 2.6, or roughly between 35% and 65% of the routine housework. Finally, respondents were given a value of 1 on *he does majority of the routine housework* if scores on the division of routine housework were equal to or greater than 2.6, which is roughly the equivalent of the male partner completing 65% or more of the housework.

In the NSFH the division of routine housework was constructed, according to each respondent's report, as the male partner's proportionate share of the total number of hours each partner spent on the five routine housework tasks. Like Kornrich et al. (2013), we truncated reports of hours for each task at the 95th percentile. Using the same cutoffs as the MARS, we divided husbands' share of routine housework into three categories to assess differences among conventional, egalitarian, and counter-conventional couples.

We also assessed *couples' total hours of housework per week*. This measure did not differentiate between core/routine and non-core/nonroutine housework tasks. Absolute increases in both types of housework affect sexual frequency similarly (Kornrich et al., 2013).

Several variables may mediate the relationship between the division of routine housework and couples' sexual relationships. These include relationship quality, satisfaction with the division of housework, and one's sense of fairness with the division of housework—all measured at the individual level. In the MARS, *relationship satisfaction* was a continuous variable ranging from 0 to 10, with higher scores indicating more satisfaction with one's romantic relationship. In the NSFH2, relationship satisfaction was measured with the question, "Taking things all together, how would you describe your marriage/relationship?" Responses ranged from 0 = *very unhappy* to 7 = *very happy*. In the MARS, *satisfaction with the division of housework* was an ordinal measure ranging from 0 = *very dissatisfied* to 3 = *very satisfied*. In the NSFH2 satisfaction with the division of housework was assessed with the question "How happy are you with the work your spouse/partner does around the house?" Responses ranged from 0 = *very unhappy* to 7 = *very happy*. For both satisfaction outcomes we adjusted the differential scaling of the MARS and NSFH2 measures by mean-centering each and presenting outcomes in terms of standard deviations. Last, respondents were asked to assess the level of fairness of the division of housework. Response options in both samples included "very unfair to me," "somewhat unfair to me," "fair to both of us," "somewhat unfair to my partner/spouse," and "very unfair to my partner/spouse." From this we constructed a dummy variable, *division of housework is fair* (1 = yes) whereby those who reported that the division of housework was "fair to both of us" were given a value of 1.

Controls. A number of variables were used as controls. *Gender* was dichotomously coded (1 = female, 0 = male), as was whether the couple were married or *cohabiting* (1 = yes). Respondent's *age*, *his hours spent in paid labor per week*, and *her hours spent in paid labor per week* were continuous variables. The presence (i.e., number) of children in the household was broken down into three categories: (a) *number of children less than age 2 in household*, (b)

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number of children ages 2 to 5 in household, and (c) *number of children ages 6 to 12 in household*. *Respondent's education* was measured categorically as less than high school, high school (reference), some college, and bachelor's degree or higher. *Male* and *female partner's self-rated health* were ordinal variables, ranging from 0 to 4, with higher scores indicating better health. Religion consisted of categories for Protestant (reference), Catholic, other, and no religion. Any category in religion that comprised less than 10% of the sample was collapsed into "other." These included Jewish, Muslim, and other. *Both attend religious services weekly* (1 = yes) was a dummy variable that assessed the frequency of religious attendance; couples in which both partners attended religious services at least weekly received a value of 1. *Time spent alone together* was a Likert item ranging from 1 to 6, with the corresponding values: 1 ("Almost never"), 2 ("Once or twice a month"), 3 ("Almost every week"), 4 ("Once a week"), 5 ("More than once a week"), and 6 ("Almost every day"). *Couples' total income* was the number of dollars (in thousands) both partners contributed to couples' income. *Female partner's share of couple's income* was the female partner's income divided by the couples' total income and ranged from 0 to 1.

Analytic Strategy

Missing values in both data sets were imputed using the set of *mi* procedures in Stata 12. We produced and combined $m = 10$ iterations of the data for both data sets. We used multiple imputation because listwise deletion resulted in a loss of 1,278 cases in the NSFH2 and 158 cases in the MARS. Analyses of sexual frequency were conducted using negative binomial regression, given the positively skewed distribution of the count of sexual encounters per month and the overdispersion of the distribution (i.e., variance was much greater than the mean). Analyses of sexual satisfaction were conducted using ordinary least squares regression. In all analyses we used clustered standard errors to account for nonindependence of reports, given that respondents were nested within couples.

Although satisfaction with one' sexual relationship is an individual-level outcome, sexual frequency is by nature a couple-level outcome. Nevertheless, individuals reported their sexual frequency independently in both surveys, leading to the possibility of discrepancy in reports. Indeed, discrepancy occurred roughly two thirds of the time in both samples, although it was more prevalent in the NSFH2. In one third of cases in the MARS the male partner reported more sex than the female partner. In another one third it was the opposite. In the NSFH2 men reported more sex than their female partner 31% of the time, but 41% of men reported less sex than their female partners. We therefore conducted both pooled analyses (i.e., both partners' individual reports) and analyses separated by gender. Gender differences were assessed with statistical tests of interaction in pooled models. Interactions of gender with the division of housework were conducted for sexual frequency, sexual satisfaction, perceived fairness, satisfaction with housework, and relationship quality. We present both aggregated and gender disaggregated results when tests of gender interactions yielded statistically significant results. In addition, we ran supplemental analyses in which we averaged respondents' reports of sexual frequency. The results of this analysis varied somewhat from those we present (see Appendix Table A1). For the sake of comparison with past studies on housework and sex (Kornrich et al., 2013), we present results from individual reports of sexual frequency.

Results

Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics for all variables in our models are presented in Table 1. Although there are some similarities across the two samples—11% of couples in both samples were cohabiting at the time of their interviews, men in both samples were slightly older than their female partners, women earned similar shares of the total income, and respondents were generally positive about their sexual relationships—in many ways there is a great deal of difference between them. This likely reflects changes over time in the characteristics of low- to moderate-income couples with children. On average, MARS respondents had some postsecondary schooling, whereas NSFH2 couples were more often only high school educated. MARS respondents also appeared to have worse health, spent less time alone with their partners, worked slightly fewer hours in the paid labor force, and were less religious than their NSFH2 counterparts.

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Table 1. *Descriptive Statistics*

	MARS				NSFH2			
	Men[a]		Women[a]		Men[b]		Women[b]	
Measures	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*
	Individual measures							
Sex measures								
Sexual frequency per month	6.195	5.388	6.344	5.333	6.427	4.894	6.884	5.173
Sexual satisfaction	−0.020	0.995	0.020	1.005	−0.044	1.029	0.042	0.970
Housework measures								
He does most of the routine housework	0.066		0.048		0.016		0.015	
She does most of the routine housework	0.564		0.691		0.795		0.843	
Routine housework shared equally	0.370		0.261		0.189		0.142	
	Individual-level controls							
Hours spent in paid labor per week	36.678	21.538	15.157	18.398	36.582	20.191	18.780	19.419
Protestant	0.370		0.398		0.489		0.489	
Catholic	0.180		0.206		0.231		0.232	
Other religion	0.215		0.234		0.166		0.166	
No religion	0.235		0.162		0.114		0.113	
Age	37.880	7.598	34.624	6.226	36.419	6.996	33.708	5.716
Self-reported health	2.513	0.981	2.466	0.952	2.945	0.805	2.917	0.845
How often spend time together alone	2.989	1.764	2.905	1.771	4.225	1.570	4.169	1.718
Less than high school	0.093		0.092		0.225		0.232	
High school	0.358		0.324		0.307		0.407	
Some college	0.362		0.399		0.306		0.276	
Bachelor's degree or more	0.187		0.185		0.119		0.085	
	Individual-level mediators							
Relationship satisfaction	0.069	0.929	−0.068	1.063	0.024	0.979	−0.024	1.055
Satisfaction with division of housework	0.229	0.879	−0.228	1.060	0.238	0.942	−0.233	1.056
Division of housework is fair	0.526		0.495		0.541		0.487	
	M		*SD*		*M*		*SD*	
	Couple-level measures							
Couple-level controls								
Hours of housework per week	43.973		30.400		57.538		27.332	
Currently cohabiting	0.113				0.106			
Couples' total income (in 2006 $)	38,387.18		18,207.66		38,309.56		17,501.86	
Her share of income	0.291				0.283			
Number of children less than age 2 in household	0.105		0.314		0.215		0.428	
Number of children age 2–5 in household	0.572		0.729		0.538		0.696	
Number of children age 6–12 in household	0.857		0.944		0.890		0.921	
Both attend religious service weekly	0.305				0.346			

Note. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households.
[a]$n = 466$. [b]$n = 1{,}314$.

Differences across the two samples extend both to respondents' reports of sexual frequency and to the division of routine housework. There was greater congruence between men's and women's reports in the MARS sample than among the NSFH2 reports. MARS respondents reported having sex just over 6 times per month, on average. This is less than reports from the NSFH2, where the mean for women was 6.9 and 6.4 for men. The decline in sexual frequency over the time period is consistent with patterns found in other nationally representative

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studies (e.g., Mercer et al., 2013). Compared to their NSFH2 counterparts, respondents in the MARS shared routine housework more equally. This is consistent with reports from recent studies using the American Time Use Survey (Parker & Wang, 2013) showing increases in egalitarianism over time. Most MARS respondents, approximately 63%, reported that the female partner did the majority of the routine housework, compared to over 80% of NSFH2 respondents. Three out of 10 MARS couples, on the other hand, stated that housework was shared more equally, compared to only 15% in the NSFH2. Counter-conventional arrangements have become more frequent as well, though they remain rare: Five percent of MARS couples reported that the male partner did the majority of routine housework, compared to less than 2% in the NSFH2. Finally, although they more often shared the housework, couples in the MARS did less housework overall, completing 14 fewer hours per week, on average, than couples in the NSFH2.

Although the division of routine domestic labor varied across the two samples, what has not changed is the fact that partners often do not concur about their divisions of labor. Men in both samples more often stated that routine housework was shared equally than did women, and women were more likely than men to report they were doing the majority of housework. We found no evidence that conflicting reports within couples were related to our dependent variables. Again, like past work, we treated reports of the division of household labor at the individual level.

Bivariate Analysis of Difference in the Division of Household Labor and Sexual Intimacy

The results from the bivariate analysis of the relationship between the division of routine housework and couples' sexual intimacy are given in Table 2. Analysis of variance tests of the MARS data indicated that sexual frequency and satisfaction varied significantly across the division of routine housework. Couples who reported sharing housework equally had sex 6.8 times per month, on average, which is 0.5 times more per month than those with conventional arrangements and over 2 times more than couples who reported that men did the bulk of routine housework. Sexual satisfaction varied little between conventional and egalitarian couples; counter-conventional couples, however, were quite dissatisfied with their sex lives compared to those in other arrangements.

This is considerably different from the pattern found in the NSFH2, where sexual satisfaction and frequency were lowest among couples who reported sharing housework. Indeed, results from the NSFH2 suggested little difference in sexual frequency between couples with conventional and counter-conventional arrangements. This strongly contradicts the notion that conventional arrangements increase sexual frequency because they elicit the sexual scripts necessary for arousal. If this were the case, sexual frequency would be lowest among those in counter-conventional arrangements.

We conducted *t* tests that reports of sexual frequency and satisfaction differed across data sets, which revealed that sexual frequency has declined for both conventional

Table 2. *Sexual Intimacy by Division of Housework for the Marital and Relationship Survey (MARS) and Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households (NSFH2)*

	Division of routine housework (*M*/*SD* or *p*)			
Sex measures	She does majority	Shared equally	He does majority	ANOVA
Sexual frequency per month				
NSFH2 ($N = 2{,}628$)	6.792/0.111	5.950/0.248	6.700/0.885	$p < .01$
MARS ($N = 932$)	6.232/0.224	6.785/0.338	4.865/0.639	$p < .05$
Independent samples *t* test for mean difference	$p < .05$	$p < .05$	$p < .10$	
Sexual satisfaction (standardized)				
NSFH2 ($N = 2{,}628$)	0.006/0.021	−0.060/0.058	0.230/0.196	$p < .10$
MARS ($N = 932$)	0.034/0.041	0.016/0.059	−0.407/0.145	$p < .01$
Independent samples *t* test for mean difference	*ns*	*ns*	$p < .01$	

Note. ANOVA = analysis of variance.

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and counter-conventional couples. Conventional couples had sex 0.6 fewer times per month in the MARS than in the NSFH2, and counter-conventional couples had sex nearly 2 fewer times per month. For egalitarian couples, however, sexual frequency has increased. Individuals who reported an equal sharing of routine housework reported having sex almost 1 time more per month in the MARS than in the NSFH2.

Multivariate Analyses of Division of Housework With Sexual Intimacy

Table 3 contains results from our multivariate analysis of couples' share of routine housework and respondents' sexual frequency and satisfaction. The full results can be found in Table A2. Consistent with the work of Kornrich and colleagues (2013), we found that a conventional division of labor among respondents in the NSFH2 was associated with greater sexual frequency compared to egalitarian arrangements. There was no evidence, however, of a monotonic fall in sexual frequency as men's shares of routine housework increased in the NSFH2. Although couples with egalitarian arrangements had significantly less sex than conventional couples, couples in which the male partner does the majority of housework did not have significantly lower sexual frequency than either conventional or egalitarian couples. We also found evidence that couples' absolute housework hours were related to the amount of sex they have, similar to the results of previous studies (Gager & Yabiku, 2010; Kornrich et al., 2013).

Consistent with our first hypothesis, the association of the division of routine housework with sexual frequency varied over time. We found no evidence of significant differences in sexual frequency between egalitarian and conventional couples in the MARS sample, as we did with NSFH2 couples. Instead, the outcomes from our negative binomial regression analyses indicate that, compared to arrangements in which routine housework is shared equally, when the male partner does the majority of the domestic labor sexual frequency was marginally and significantly lower ($b = -0.273, p = .051$). Total housework hours remained significantly and positively related to sexual frequency in the MARS.

To formally test differences across the two samples in the association of the division of housework with sexual frequency we pooled the two samples ($N = 3{,}560$) and conducted interaction tests (results available on request). The results indicated differences in the coefficients for all three categories of the division of housework (conventional, egalitarian, counter-conventional) across data sets. Net of controls, egalitarian couples in the NSFH2 had significantly less sex than those in the MARS ($b = -0.212$, $p < .01$), whereas conventional ($b = 0.149$, $p = .052$) and counter-conventional couples ($b = 0.418$, $p < .05$) had significantly more sex in the NSFH2.

Table 3. *Negative Binomial and Ordinary Least Squares Regression of Division of Routine Housework on Sexual Frequency and Sexual Satisfaction for Married and Cohabiting Couples With Minor Children in Home*

	Sexual frequency per month		Sexual satisfaction	
	MARS[a]	NSFH Wave 2[b]	MARS[a]	NSFH Wave 2[b]
Predictor	B (*SE*)	B (*SE*)	B (*SE*)	B (*SE*)
Division of housework (ref.: shared equally)				
She does majority of housework	−.047 (.077)	.098* (.047)	.023 (.077)	.083 (.051)
He does majority of housework	−.273† (.140)	.142 (.154)	−.323* (.154)	.140 (.145)
Couples' hours of housework per week	.003** (.001)	.002** (.001)	.002† (.001)	.002* (.001)

Note. All models include controls for gender, respondents' age, marital status, his and her hours in paid work per week, total couple income, her share of income, couples' total hours of weekly housework, respondents' religion, both attend religious services at least weekly, respondents' and partners' health, amount of time couple spends alone together, number of children under age 2, number of children ages 2–5, number of children ages 6–12, and respondents' education. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households; ref. = reference category.

[a]$n = 932$. [b]$n = 2{,}628$.

†$p < .10$. *$p < .05$. **$p < .01$.

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The results also revealed a cohort change in the association between the division of routine household labor and sexual satisfaction. How couples arranged their division of routine housework mattered more for satisfaction with the sexual relationship among the more recent cohort (MARS). Again, we confirmed this by pooling the two samples and conducting formal tests of interaction (not shown). There is little evidence from the NSFH2 that the division of routine domestic labor was associated with couples' sexual satisfaction. This finding differs from those of Kornrich and colleagues (2013), who found, in their more age- and class-diverse sample of NSFH2 respondents, that a conventional division of labor resulted in increased sexual satisfaction among married women. In the MARS, on the other hand, counter-conventional arrangements significantly reduced sexual satisfaction compared to egalitarian relationships. The difference between the two samples was statistically significant at the $p < .05$ level. We found no difference in sexual satisfaction between those in egalitarian and conventional arrangements in the MARS sample. Increases in couples' total housework hours were positively associated with the level of satisfaction with the sexual relationship in both samples. Tests for gender variation in the relationship of the division of housework with sexual frequency and satisfaction revealed no evidence of gender differences ($p > .10$).

Relationship Quality, Satisfaction With the Division of Housework, and Fairness

To explain the association of the division of housework on sexual frequency and sexual satisfaction we examined three possible mediators: (a) relationship satisfaction, (b) satisfaction with the division of housework, and (c) feelings of fairness with the division of housework. Results from the NSFH2 and MARS indicated no general association between the division of routine housework and couples' overall relationship satisfaction (see Table 4). Nonetheless, the results indicated gender variation in the MARS sample. Conventional arrangements were associated with lower relationship satisfaction compared to egalitarian relationships for women only, whereas counter-conventional arrangements resulted in lower relationship satisfaction compared to egalitarian arrangements for men only. We also found no evidence of a general association between the division of housework and satisfaction with housework arrangements in the NSFH2; nevertheless, gender differences again emerged. Compared to egalitarian arrangements, conventional arrangements resulted in lower levels of satisfaction for women, whereas they resulted in higher levels of satisfaction for men. Regardless of gender, conventional couples in the NSFH2 were less likely to note that the division of housework was fair than egalitarian couples.

In contrast to the NSFH2, results from the MARS showed that egalitarian arrangements were associated with greater satisfaction with one's housework arrangement than other arrangements. The overall results, however, masked significant gender differences. Disaggregated gender results showed that women in conventional arrangements were significantly less satisfied with the division of housework than were women in egalitarian arrangements. The opposite pattern emerged for men; moreover, the results indicated lower levels of satisfaction for men in counter-conventional arrangements compared to those in egalitarian arrangements. Although it may appear that the association of the division of housework with housework satisfaction strengthened across the samples, interaction tests when samples were pooled uncovered only one significant difference in coefficients across the two data sets: Among men, lower levels of satisfaction associated with counter-conventional arrangements compared to egalitarian ones were marginally smaller ($p < .10$) in the NSFH2 than in the MARS.

Finally, the MARS results revealed that, for both partners, egalitarian arrangements were related to a significantly greater sense of fairness with the division of housework than either conventional or counter-conventional arrangements. The association of egalitarianism with fairness has increased across cohorts; the differences between conventional and egalitarian arrangements were nearly twice as large in the MARS as in the NSFH2, whereas the differences between counter-conventional and egalitarian arrangements were almost five times larger. In fact, formal interaction tests from pooling the samples (results not shown) demonstrated that both conventional ($b = 0.625$, $p < .01$) and counter-conventional ($b = 1.289$, $p < .05$) couples in the NSFH2 more often viewed their arrangements as fair compared to their peers in the MARS, whereas egalitarian couples in the

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Table 4. *Regression Analyses of Fairness, Satisfaction With Division of Labor, and Relationship Quality on the Division of Routine Housework*

	MARS[a]			NSFH2[b]		
Predictor	Relationship satisfaction B (*SE*)	Satisfaction with division of housework B (*SE*)	Division of housework is fair B (*SE*)	Relationship satisfaction B (*SE*)	Satisfaction with division of housework B (*SE*)	Division of housework is fair B (*SE*)
All						
Division of housework (ref. = shared equally)						
She does majority of routine housework	−.079 (.083)	−.130† (.073)	−.974*** (.189)	.049 (.060)	−.051 (.061)	−.537*** (.142)
He does majority of routine housework	−.210 (.162)	−.345* (.163)	−1.472*** (.397)	.096 (.176)	−.093 (.202)	−.309 (.441)
Women[c]						
Division of housework (ref. = shared equally)						
She does majority of routine housework	−.204$^{\dagger d}$ (.117)	−.632^{***d} (.108)	−1.302*** (.271)	.027 (.087)	−.461^{***d} (.095)	−.514* (.200)
He does majority of routine housework	−.012^{d} (.183)	.241^{d} (.212)	−1.592** (.556)	.183 (.259)	.034 (.298)	−.754 (.520)
Men[c]						
Division of housework (ref. = shared equally)						
She does majority of routine housework	.051 (.097)	.333*** (.092)	−.759*** (.237)	.075 (.076)	.292*** (.074)	−.562** (.193)
He does majority of routine housework	−.354† (.190)	−.815*** (.221)	−1.491** (.477)	−.022 (.250)	−.177 (.280)	.128 (.690)

Note. all models include controls for gender, respondents' age, marital status, his and her hours in paid work per week, total couple income, her share of income, his and her hours of weekly housework, respondents' religion, respondents' frequency of religious attendance, respondents' and partners' health, amount of time couple spends alone together, number of children under age 2, number of children ages 2–5, number of children ages 6–12, and respondents' education. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households; ref. = reference category.

[a]$n = 932$. [b]$n = 2{,}628$. [c]$n = 466$ for the MARS; $n = 1{,}314$ for the NSFH2. [d]Significantly different ($p < .05$) from men.

$^{\dagger}p < .10$. $^{*}p < .05$. $^{**}p < .01$. $^{***}p < .001$.

NSFH2 less often considered their arrangements as fair compared to their MARS counterparts ($b = -0.511, p < .05$).

Mediation Tests

Tests of mediation, the results of which are presented in Table 5, indicated that higher levels of relationship quality, satisfaction with the division of housework, and sense of fairness in housework were associated with more sex and more satisfaction with ones' sex life in both samples. In partial support of our second hypothesis, results from Sobel–Goodman tests of mediation provided evidence that differences in sexual frequency and sexual satisfaction across housework arrangements in the MARS and NSFH2 were mediated by perceived fairness in the division of housework. Given that we found no gender differences in perceived fairness, this likely explains our finding of no gender differences in the association of the division of housework and sexual intimacy. As shown in Model 2, when fairness in the division of housework was accounted for, differences between egalitarian and counter-conventional couples were reduced by 22%, from −0.273 (see Table 3) to −0.214. In Models 4 through 6 we examined possible mediation in the NSFH2. As shown in Table 5, there appeared to be little mediation, as the coefficients for the division

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Table 5. *Mediating Effects of Fairness and Satisfaction With Division of Labor and Relationship Quality for Association of Division of Routine Housework With Sexual Frequency and Satisfaction*

	Sexual frequency per month						Sexual satisfaction					
	MARS			NSFH2			MARS			NSFH2		
Measures	Model 1 B (*SE*)	Model 2 B (*SE*)	Model 3 B (*SE*)	Model 4 B (*SE*)	Model 5 B (*SE*)	Model 6 B (*SE*)	Model 7 B (*SE*)	Model 8 B (*SE*)	Model 9 B (*SE*)	Model 10 B (*SE*)	Model 11 B (*SE*)	Model 12 B (*SE*)
Division of routine housework (ref. = shared equally)												
She does majority of routine housework	−0.036 (0.077)	−0.008 (0.078)	−0.047 (0.078)	0.100*(0.049)	0.104*(0.049)	0.097*(0.049)	0.050 (0.074)	0.095 (0.075)	0.058 (0.067)	0.116*(0.053)	0.107†(0.057)	0.072 (0.048)
He does majority of routine housework	−0.252†(0.138)	−0.214 (0.142)	−0.225 (0.146)	0.147 (0.142)	0.147 (0.140)	0.133 (0.141)	−0.252†(0.147)	−0.216 (0.147)	−0.231 (0.146)	0.173 (0.129)	0.156 (0.141)	0.112 (0.134)
Couples' hours of housework	0.003** (.001)	0.003** (0.001)	0.002*(0.001)	0.002*(0.001)	0.002*(0.001)	0.002*(0.001)	0.002*(0.001)	0.002†(0.001)	0.002†(0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Satisfaction with division of housework	0.052 (0.032)			0.049** (0.016)			0.207*** (0.035)			0.246*** (0.020)		
Division of housework is fair		0.154*(0.064)			0.055†(0.031)			0.323*** (0.071)			.0159*** (0.039)	
Relationship satisfaction			0.147*** (0.044)			0.102*** (0.019)			0.439*** (0.039)			0.370*** (0.022)
Intercept	1.761** (0.323)	1.654** (0.324)	1.880** (0.325)	2.039*** (0.187)	1.994*** (0.187)	2.102*** (0.187)	−0.751*(0.341)	−1.015 (0.342)	−0.419 (0.314)	−0.619*** (0.169)	−0.926*** (0.180)	−0.493** (0.162)
Sobel–Goodman mediation tests of division of housework		B/*SE*			B/*SE*			B/*SE*			B/*SE*	
Satisfaction with division of housework		−0.142 (0.093)			−0.017 (0.025)			−0.085*(0.036)			−0.018 (0.022)	
Division of housework is fair		−0.420** (0.162)			−0.126†(0.065)			−0.127*** (0.038)			−0.050*** (0.013)	
Relationship satisfaction		−0.158 (0.124)			0.037 (0.055)			−0.091 (0.071)			0.032 (0.037)	

Note. All models include controls for: gender, respondents' age, marital status, his and her hours in paid work per week, total couple income, her share of income, his and her hours of weekly housework, respondents' religion, respondents' frequency of religious attendance, respondents' and partners' health, amount of time couple spends alone together, number of children under age 2, number of children ages 2–5, number of children ages 6–12, and respondents' education. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households; ref. = reference category.

†$p < .10$. *$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

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of routine housework are unchanged across models.

We next examined mediation of the association between the division of routine housework and sexual satisfaction (Models 7–12). In the MARS, when satisfaction with the division of housework was controlled in Model 7, we observed a 22% change in the difference between egalitarian and counter-conventional couples, from −0.323 (see Table 3) to −0.252. Housework fairness also mediated the relationship, accounting for 33% of the association of the division of housework on sexual satisfaction, as shown in Model 8. In the NSFH2 we saw little evidence of attenuation; instead, the association of the division of housework with sexual satisfaction appeared to be suppressed by the omission of the mediators from the models. Indeed, when satisfaction with housework and housework fairness were included in Models 10 and 11, the coefficient of conventional arrangements increased to statistical significance. Sobel–Goodman tests identified perceived housework fairness as the sole intervening mechanism, however. This indicates that conventional arrangements were perceived as less fair than egalitarian arrangements by couples in the NSFH2, and this masks the positive association of conventional arrangements with sexual satisfaction, because fairness was also positively associated with satisfaction.

Discussion

In this study we set out to reassess the association between the division of routine household labor and couples' reports of sexual frequency and satisfaction, given changes in family behaviors and the liberalization of gender attitudes over the past few decades. Our analysis built on past research that used data from the NSFH2 (Gager & Yabiku, 2010; Kornrich et al., 2013) in that we used data from a more recently collected sample of low- to moderate-income couples residing with minor children, gathered in 2006, to examine potential changes over time in the association between housework and couples' sexual relationships. Our findings highlighted that the shift toward more egalitarian sharing of routine housework has not radically undermined one important dimension of marriage and couple relationships: sexual intimacy. Contemporary couples in which both male and female partners contributed to the important work of maintaining the home fared well in that, unlike in the NSFH2 sample, they did not experience lower sexual frequency or satisfaction relative to their conventional counterparts. This shift appears to stem from the greater sense of fairness that egalitarianism fosters in couples compared to conventional arrangements, a difference that has grown over time. Nonetheless, couples in the MARS sample seemed discontented when they reversed tradition entirely, with counter-conventional couples reporting lower sexual frequency and satisfaction than the rest of the sample.

Our most notable finding is that the association between the division of routine housework and couples' sexual relationships has changed over time. Couples who reported more egalitarian divisions of routine housework fare better with regard to sexual intimacy today than they did 20 years ago. Whereas egalitarian couples had the lowest sexual frequency and satisfaction in the early 1990s, today they have the highest sexual frequency, although it is not significantly greater than conventional couples. One possible explanation for this change is a shift in desired sexual scripts. An assumed preference for gendered sexual scripts historically has benefited conventional couples in terms of sexual frequency and satisfaction. In the early 1990s, for example, P. Schwartz (1995) found that one problem equally sharing couples faced was a lack of sexual intimacy. She noted at the time that those in equal sharing marriages would need to transform conventional models of passion to eroticize sameness rather than difference. Lavee and Katz (2002) also suggested that couples undergoing a cultural transition may experience discrepancies between their gender role attitudes and the division of domestic labor; this dissonance could be a source of strain and interpersonal conflict that generated relationship dissatisfaction. Today, the majority of young adults express preferences for egalitarian unions in which both partners share household chores and financial provision (Gerson, 2010). Although the proportion attaining such a division remains in the minority, those who do attain it find it satisfying and view it as fairer than any other arrangement. This seems to have led to more frequent and more satisfying sex among peer couples, relative to their conventional counterparts.

Although egalitarian sexual scripts may now be "sexier" than they were in the past, we do not have direct evidence to support this point;

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instead, our results suggest that the division of routine domestic labor is associated with couples' sexual relationships primarily through perceived fairness with the division of housework. Perceived fairness matters greatly to sexual intimacy and was highest for egalitarian couples in both samples, an association that strengthened over time. Perceptions of housework equity mediated the higher levels of sexual frequency and satisfaction among egalitarian couples compared to counter-conventional couples in the MARS while suppressing the higher levels of sexual satisfaction among conventional couples in the NSFH2. In fact, our results suggest that sexual satisfaction would have been even higher in conventional couples compared to egalitarian couples 20 years ago were it not for the perceived inequity of female responsibility for routine housework in conventional couples.

Perceived inequality has deleterious impacts on couples' sex lives, and today more men and women believe that conventional or counter-conventional domestic arrangements are unfair. Thus, the feelings among today's couples that egalitarian arrangements are fair and satisfactory have eliminated any sexual advantage that conventional couples had in the past because they were able to rely on traditional sexual scripts to bolster their sexual frequency and satisfaction. In fact, although both conventional and counter-conventional couples within the MARS sample have less sex today than do their NSFH2 counterparts, egalitarian couples in the MARS sample actually reported higher sexual frequency than their NSFH2 counterparts. More couples today expect that equality is something that must be practiced, not just preached.

Whereas both men and women are more comfortable expanding gender roles to include men sharing a larger proportion of the housework, such acceptance clearly does not extend to men doing the majority of the housework. Modern couples in which male partners performed the majority of routine housework reported less sex and less satisfaction with their sexual relationships than other couples. This is also a change, as sexual intimacy in counter-conventional couples 20 years ago did not differ from couples with conventional housework divisions. Although young men and women may be able to confidently bend their definitions of manhood and womanhood to include equal sharing partners, it may be too difficult to expand those categories to include a male partner who does the majority of the housework. Caution should clearly be taken in interpreting these results given the small size of the counter-conventional groups in both samples. Differences in composition among the counter-conventionals in the NSFH2 and MARS may be driving these findings. MARS counter-conventional couples spent less time together and were less healthy than their NSHF2 counterparts, which might help explain their decreased sex lives. Moreover, counter-conventional arrangements were perceived as much less fair by both partners and resulted in less satisfaction for men today compared to 20 years ago. Whether this represents a cohort shift in these kinds of couples is unclear, yet it is consistent with the increasingly precarious position of the middle class and those on the bottom of the income distribution, for whom difficult and undesirable decisions about paid and unpaid labor arrangements are often the reality. Although the number of stay-at-home dads has increased over time (Kramer, Kelly, & McCulloch, 2015), male homemaking does not appear to be something men are content with, in large part because such arrangements are often driven by economic factors (Chesley, 2011).

Although men and women often view the division of labor differently and benefit differentially from their arrangements, we found no evidence that the relationship of the division of housework with sexual intimacy varied significantly by gender. Although this may surprise some, our finding—that the association between the division of housework and sexual intimacy is mediated by feelings of fairness—is consistent with past work showing no gender differences in the effect of perceived equity on marital quality (Frisco & Williams, 2003).

Like most, our study is not without limitations. First, our measures of the division of housework in the MARS were non-numeric and limited to routine housework items. This limited our ability to draw direct comparisons between our findings and those of past studies, especially regarding the consequences of the division of non-routine housework. A second limitation is that the data are cross-sectional. It is possible, for example, that greater sexual satisfaction actually increases perceived fairness with the division of housework. Nonetheless, our logical

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temporal assumption is that greater perceived fairness in the division of household labor leads to increased sexual satisfaction. This presumption is supported in recent work by Johnson and colleagues (Johnson, Galambos, & Anderson, 2016), who found that among German couples, male partners' reports of sharing housework fairly were associated with more frequent sexual encounters and higher sexual satisfaction a year later. Finally, the MARS and our subset of the NSFH2 were not nationally representative, and our findings may not be applicable to older, childless, gay or lesbian, and more affluent Americans. In fact, one could argue that these results may understate the differences between egalitarian and conventional couples given higher rates of egalitarianism among higher socioeconomic status (SES) couples. Higher SES individuals are more likely to espouse egalitarian ideals, and thus their sense of equity would likely be more sensitive to the division of housework. In fact, some evidence suggests that couples with high levels of education or earnings have more egalitarian divisions of labor (e.g., Gupta, 2007; Legerski & Cornwall, 2010) and, among cohabitors, at least, feel more satisfied with their divisions than do their working-class peers (Miller & Carlson, 2016). Because perceived equity is a primary link between the division of housework and sex, achieving an egalitarian arrangement, or feeling that one's conventional arrangement is equitable, may lead to even more frequent and more satisfying sex among high-SES couples than their less advantaged counterparts.

Over the past several decades, preferences for gendered divisions of labor within intimate unions have changed (Pedulla & Thébaud, 2015; Thornton & Young-Demarco, 2001). Contemporary couples desire to share paid work and domestic responsibilities with their partners in ways that differ from those they observed in their families of origin (Gerson, 2010). As egalitarian ideals have diffused, cultural sexual scripts have expanded to incorporate gender equality as a desirable possibility. Kornrich and collaborators (2013) noted that "sexuality is governed by elements of femininity and masculinity through appropriately gendered performances of household labor that coincide with sexual scripts organizing heterosexual desire" (p. 38). Our results suggest that a broader acceptance that egalitarian divisions of labor are fair means that conventional household arrangements are no longer a necessity for a full and satisfying sex life among today's young adults.

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Appendix

Table A1. *Negative Binomial Regression of Division of Routine Housework on Sexual Frequency for Married and Cohabiting Couples With Minor Children in the Home*

	Sexual frequency per month			
Predictor	MARS, reports averaged[a] B (*SE*)	MARS, reports not averaged[a] B (*SE*)	NSFH2, reports averaged[b] B (*SE*)	NSFH2, reports not averaged[b] B (*SE*)
Division of housework (ref.: shared equally)				
She does majority of housework	−0.050 (0.079)	−0.047 (0.077)	0.107* (0.047)	0.098* (0.049)
He does majority of housework	−0.211 (0.139)	−.273† (0.140)	0.080 (0.118)	0.142 (0.140)

Note. All models include controls for gender, respondents' age, marital status, his and her hours in paid work per week, total couple income, her share of income, couples' total hours of weekly housework, respondents' religion, both attend religious services at least weekly, male and female partners' health, amount of time couple spends alone together, number of children under age 2, number of children ages 2–5, number of children ages 6–12, and respondents' education. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households; ref. = reference category.

[a]$n = 932$. [b]$n = 2{,}628$.

†$p < .10$. *$p < .05$.

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Table A2. *Full Results of Both Men and Women for Negative Binomial, Ordinary Least Squares Regression, and Ordered Logit Regression of Division of Routine Housework on Sexual Frequency and Sexual Satisfaction for Married and Cohabiting Couples With Minor Children in the Home*

	Sexual frequency per month		Sexual satisfaction	
Predictor	MARS[a] B (*SE*)	NSFH2[b] B (*SE*)	MARS[a] B (*SE*)	NSFH2[b] B (*SE*)
Division of housework (ref.: shared equally)				
She does majority of housework	−0.047 (0.077)	0.098* (0.049)	0.023 (0.077)	0.083 (0.056)
He does majority of housework	−0.273† (0.140)	0.142 (0.140)	−0.323* (0.154)	0.140 (0.140)
Couples' hours of housework per week	0.003** (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.002† (0.001)	0.002† (0.001)
Female (1 = yes)	−.025 (.041)	.006 (.025)	−.005 (.056)	.067* (.029)
Her hours spent in paid labor per week	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.000 (0.001)
His hours spent in paid labor per week	0.001 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.001)	−0.000 (0.002)	−0.002* (0.001)
Currently cohabiting	0.218* (0.108)	−0.292*** (0.060)	−0.154 (0.129)	1.588*** (0.046)
Her share of income	−0.094 (0.164)	−0.039 (0.085)	−0.052 (0.142)	0.023 (0.081)
Couples' total income (in 2006 $)	0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)	0.000 (0.000)	−0.000 (0.000)
Religious affiliation (ref. = no religion)				
Protestant	−0.045 (0.094)	−0.021 (0.057)	0.084 (0.102)	−0.005 (0.060)
Catholic	0.078 (0.109)	−0.030 (0.062)	0.047 (0.115)	−0.038 (0.065)
Other religion	−0.085 (0.099)	−0.021 (0.071)	−0.081 (0.112)	−0.013 (0.071)
Both attend religious service weekly	−0.030 (0.085)	0.008 (0.038)	−0.008 (0.086)	0.029 (0.044)
Age	−0.021*** (0.005)	−0.020*** (0.003)	−0.014* (0.006)	−0.006* (0.003)
Male partner self-reported health	0.099* (0.044)	0.005 (0.024)	0.140** (0.044)	0.086*** (0.022)
Female partner self-reported health	0.028 (0.043)	0.049* (0.024)	0.130** (0.045)	0.072** (0.025)
How often spend time together alone	0.109*** (0.019)	0.089*** (0.011)	0.134*** (0.019)	0.152*** (0.013)
Respondent's education (ref. = high school)				
Less than high school	−0.011 (0.103)	0.038 (0.043)	0.114 (0.131)	0.119** (0.045)
Some college	−0.219** (0.069)	−0.055 (0.040)	−0.081 (0.076)	−0.038 (0.041)
Bachelor's degree or more	−0.295** (0.094)	−0.113† (0.063)	−0.302** (0.097)	−0.148* (0.066)
Number of children less than age 2 in household	0.028 (0.110)	−0.075 (0.052)	−0.025 (0.112)	−0.065 (0.046)
Number of children age 2–5 in household	0.028 (0.055)	−0.027 (0.032)	−0.007 (0.059)	−0.046 (0.029)
Number of children age 6–12 in household	0.070† (0.039)	0.055* (0.021)	0.058 (0.041)	−0.009 (0.021)
Intercept	1.752*** (0.324)	1.989*** (0.188)	−0.858* (0.349)	−1.066*** (0.185)

Note. MARS = Marital and Relationship Survey; NSFH2 = Wave 2 of the National Survey of Families and Households; ref. = reference category.

[a]$n = 932$. [b]$n = 2{,}628$.

†$p < .10$. *$p < .05$. **$p < .01$. ***$p < .001$.

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